

Savannah by steamboat around 8:30 a.m. and found the position on the 6-mile (10-km) wide battlefield desperate. Many raw troops had fled the battle, cowering along the riverbank. Leaving Sherman in control of the Union defense on the right flank, Grant ordered Prentiss to hold the line in the center in a position that would become known as the Hornet's Nest. By early afternoon the Union left flank was collapsing, some units having sustained in excess of 50 percent casualties. Confederate losses were also high, however. General Johnston was riding forward to urge his exhausted men to press for victory when he was wounded and bled to death. Beauregard took over command.

The Union onslaught

The defense of the Hornet's Nest ended around 5:30 p.m., when 62 Confederate field guns were trained upon the few thousand defenders. By then, Union reinforcements were arriving to help Grant hold a last-ditch line along a ridge overlooking a steep ravine. In gathering twilight, Beauregard soon abandoned an attempt to assault this strong defensive position in the face of a concentrated artillery barrage and fire from river gunboats.

The two exhausted armies endured a night of heavy rain and thunderstorms. Many shaken officers on the Union side felt beaten, but when Grant was asked if he intended to retreat he replied, "No! I propose to attack at daylight and whip them." Buell's and Wallace's fresh troops continued to arrive throughout the night. By the morning of April 7, Union forces had the superiority of numbers to launch a counteroffensive. This time it was Beauregard who was caught by surprise. Rebel troops fell back in disarray as Union forces advanced across the previous day's corpse-strewn battlefield. After hard fighting in the early afternoon, Beauregard, fearing a rout, ordered a general retreat.

Grant did not attempt a pursuit, but on the next day he sent Sherman on a reconnaissance mission to see whether the Confederates were regrouping for another attack. This led to a clash with Colonel Nathan Bedford Forrest's cavalry at Fallen Timbers, in